PhraseNote User Guide

Phone-first composition sketch app · v0.8.35

1. What is PhraseNote?

PhraseNote is a sketch pad for song ideas. You paint a chord progression, add a melody on a piano roll or a staff, listen to it with an automatic accompaniment and drums, and export it as a MIDI file to continue in a DAW such as Ardour. It is designed for a phone screen (about 360 px wide), and works in landscape too.

- Chord Track: paint chords on a grid; the app plays them with a chosen accompaniment style, bass and drums.
- Melody Track: write a melody on a piano roll or a staff, or play it in with the on-screen keyboard.
- Everything is saved automatically on your device. Export MIDI to take it to your computer.

Installing as an app

Open the site in your phone browser and use the menu item for installing or adding it to the home screen. It then opens full screen and works offline after the first load. Project data and SoundFont files stay on your phone.

2. Screen overview

Area	What it does
Play / Back to start	Starts and stops playback; the second button returns to the beginning.
BPM − / +	Tempo. You can also type a number (40–200).
Drum button + arrow	Left part turns drums on or off. The arrow opens the drum pattern list.
Undo / Redo	Steps back or forward through your edits.
Time / Key / Scale	Time signature (2/4, 3/4, 4/4, 5/4, 6/8, 9/8, 12/8), key and scale (Major, Minor, Harmonic minor).
Chord Track / Melody Track tabs	Switch between the two editors. The tabs stay visible while you scroll.
Bottom bar	Setup (gear) always. Keys (keyboard icon) appears only on the Melody Track.

3. Chord Track

Painting chords

- The palette shows the seven chords of the current key and scale (Roman numeral and chord name), plus Erase. Tap one to hear it and select it.
- Tap or drag across the grid to paint the selected chord; tap a filled cell to clear it.

- Cell sets how long one cell is (Beat, 2 Beats or Bar, depending on the time signature). Bars sets the length: 4, 8 or 16 bars.
- Bass adds a bass line under the chords. 7th turns the chords into seventh chords. The /– button chooses a slash-chord bass note by scale degree.
- The dice button (Random) fills the grid with a random progression. Undo brings the previous one back.

4. Accompaniment

The Accompaniment box decides how the chords are played. Pick a style from the chips; the controls below fine-tune it. Tap a control's name to open a short help box in English and Korean.

Styles

Group	Styles
Classic	Block, Beat, 8th, Pop stabs, Ballad arp, Arp up, Arp up-down, Alberti, Offbeat, Funk stabs, Strum, Pad, Waltz, Bossa comp, Gospel
Modern	K-ballad piano, Anticipation, City pop, R&B stabs, Hip-hop keys, Lo-fi keys, Pluck 16th, House piano, Trance gate, Arp 16th, Synth arp, Rolled chords
Jazz / Soul	Charleston, Freddie Green, Jazz comping, Neo-soul, Rhodes sustain, Shell voicing
Rock / Folk	Power chug, Power sustain, Boom-chick, Fingerpick, Staccato 8ths

> Rhythm-grid styles work in 4/4 only (Waltz in 3/4 only). In other time signatures the app falls back to Beat, and the style chips are hidden. Choosing a style also applies its recommended Voicing, Color, Bass, Strum, Late, Swing and Loose settings automatically; you can change any of them afterwards.

Controls

Control	Meaning
Voicing	Close = notes packed together. Open = second-highest note down an octave. Spread = Open plus the top note up an octave. Smooth keeps each chord close to the previous one.
Color	Adds colour notes: add9, sus, 6/9, 9th. Not applied to diminished or augmented chords.
Bass	Root = held root. Root+5 = root then the fifth on beat 3. Octave = 8th notes between low and high root. Kick = follows the drum kick.
Strum	Delay between the notes of a chord (0–60 ms), like a guitar strum. Off = all at once.
Late	Plays chords slightly behind the beat while bass and drums stay on time (0–60 ms).
Swing	Delays off-beat 8th notes of chords, bass and drums. About 55–65% = jazz/shuffle, 100% = triplet feel.
Loose	Random tiny timing slips so it sounds less robotic. Heard in playback only; not written to the MIDI file.

5. Drums

- Tap the drum button to turn drums on or off. Tap the arrow beside it to choose a pattern; the pattern plays as a preview and drums are switched on.

- Patterns are grouped: Basic, Rock, Pop, Funk / Soul, Hip-hop, Reggae / Latin, Electronic, Metal, Korean, and Custom (My pattern). Many are approximations of the genre feel.
- Genre patterns work in 4/4; in other time signatures the app uses a simple rock 8th pattern.
- To edit, open Setup → Sound → Drums → Pattern → Edit. The grid has lanes for kick, snare, side stick, hi-hat, open hat, ride and crash; tap steps to toggle. Resolution, Test, From preset and Clear are at the top of the editor.

6. Melody Track

Roll and Staff

- Mode switches between Roll (piano roll) and Staff (notation). The chord progression is shown above the roll as a guide.
- Pickup adds a pickup (anacrusis) measure before bar 1.
- Auto-Velocity sets how much the melody follows the velocity pattern in Setup (0% = flat, 100% = full).
- Zoom − / + changes the horizontal scale.

Tools

Tool	Roll	Staff
Pen	Tap to add a note; drag to stretch or change pitch; tap a note to delete.	Hold to hear the pitch, drag up or down to change it, release to place; tap a note to delete.
Move	Drag a note to move it; drag its right end to resize.	Tap a note to select; drag to move; use the arrow buttons to nudge (▲▼ semitone, ◀▶ one 16th); Del deletes.
Pan	Drag to scroll without editing.	Drag to scroll without editing.

In Roll, Len and Snap choose the default note length and the grid. In Staff, choose the note value, dot and accidental before placing.

Quantize

Open the Quantize box, choose a Grid, a Strength (0–100%) and Length handling, then press Quantize all notes to tidy the timing.

Keys keyboard

The Keys button in the bottom bar opens an on-screen keyboard (Melody Track only; it is off by default). Use the ◀ ▶ buttons to shift the range.

- Live mode: press Rec, then Play; a count-in bar starts the take (Count-in can be switched off). Quant snaps recorded notes (Off, 16, 8, 4). Latency measures and compensates the audio delay of your phone.
- Step mode: play a note and the cursor moves on. Rest skips a step, Back removes the previous note, Start returns to the beginning.

7. Setup

Open Setup with the gear button at the bottom.

Item	Meaning
Clear all chords / Clear melody	Erase the chord grid or the melody.

Item	Meaning
New / Open / Save project	Projects are saved as .phrasenote files. Save keeps a copy you can reopen later or move to another device.
Export MIDI	Chords, Bass and Melody go out as separate tracks, plus Drums on channel 10 when the drum button is on. Humanize and Loose are not written.
Basic Synth / SoundFont	Basic Synth works without any files. SoundFont uses sampled instruments.
Load SoundFont	Add a .sf2 file (for example GeneralUser GS). It is stored on the device. Each track (Melody, Chords, Bass, Drums) can use a sound from any loaded file, with its own volume.
Save / Load preset	Save the sound choices as a .pnsound file and load them again.
Reverb / Master	Reverb amount and overall volume (50 = normal).
Buffer	Low latency feels best on the keys but can crackle on some phones; Stable never crackles but sounds a little later. Changing it reloads the page.
Velocity	Four accent levels per beat group with presets (Standard, Flat, Backbeat, Downbeat). Humanize randomises playback velocity only; exported MIDI keeps the set values.

8. Tips and limits

- Data is stored in your browser on this phone. Clearing the site's data, or uninstalling the browser, can erase projects and SoundFonts: use Save project regularly.
- Some new accompaniment styles and genre drum patterns are 4/4-only.
- There is no triplet grid; shuffle and swing-jazz feel come from the Swing slider.
- Drum and accompaniment patterns are approximations of each genre, not exact transcriptions.